PR outline by paragraph

Below is a paragraph-by-paragraph outline of the standard format that you should use for PRs, the key point for each paragraph, why it matters, and examples for reference. Using this format makes it easy for team members and senior leaders to understand what you propose to build and announce. Deviating from this format delays approval, wastes the leadership team's time explaining format deviations, and often triggers the need for a second review.

Headline and subhead, list of customers (write this last!)

The headline is a crisp statement of the service announcement, typically written as “Amazon Announces <x>”. The subhead is a single sentence summary of what you are launching and the most important benefit the customer receives. This is the one sentence you would tell a customer in an elevator. Keep it simple and do not use end punctuation. *See Internal PR Brief part 3a in Appendix 6.* The headline and subhead are often followed by a list of customers using the new service (include the customers from Paragraph 6, *Customer Testimonials*). This list is usually aspirational when you draft the PR. The headline, subhead, and list of customers are important because they provide key information at a glance. Note that should NOT use the code name in the PR--use the service name. Here is an example from the Amazon Location Service PR:

Amazon Web Services Announces Amazon Location Service

New geolocation service helps developers add location data to their applications securely, affordably, and easily

Starbucks, Airbus, and Comcast among first customers using Amazon Location Service

Paragraph One: Summarize what the service or product is and what it provides to customers

Paragraph one should start with the date line that specifies the city and intended launch date for the service (for example, “LAS VEGAS – November 28, 2018”). This sets expectations for when the service will launch. The first paragraph draws on the answers to questions one and three in the Five Questions (*Who is the customer? What is the most important customer benefit?*) to summarize the service and its value. *See Internal PR Brief part 1, 2b, and 3c in Appendix 6.* This paragraph is important because many readers do not move beyond it. Make it count and don’t bury the lede. If there is a relevant category for the service, say so. Include a short call-to action (for example, “to get started with <<service>>, visit: <<web page>>) as the final sentence of the paragraph. Here’s an example of paragraph one from the Amazon Location Service PR:

> SEATTLE – (BUSINESS WIRE) – December 2, 2020 – Amazon Web Services, Inc. (AWS), an Amazon.com company (NASDAQ: AMZN), announced Amazon Location Service, a new geolocation service that enables developers to easily add location information to their applications. With Amazon Location Service, developers can build applications that provide maps and points of interest, recommend routes, track resources, trigger actions based on location, and convert street addresses into geographic coordinates. Waypoint pulls high-quality data from three location-based service (LBS) leaders— Esri, TomTom, and Mapbox—and enables customers to build location-enabled applications faster, up to 20 times cheaper than common alternatives, and without giving up control of their proprietary location data. Learn more at aws.amazon.com/amazonlocationservice.

Paragraph Two: Describe the opportunity or problem: The Setup

The second paragraph helps readers put themselves in the position of the target customer. It draws on the answer to question two in the Five Questions document (*What is the customer problem or opportunity?*). The key point is that the customer is experiencing pain (that the service will address in the next paragraph) or is not yet able to take advantage of functionality that the service will provide. *See Internal PR Brief part 3b in Appendix 6.* This paragraph is important because it provides "the setup" as to why we are building the service. The most typical problem people make in writing paragraph two is to denigrate an existing AWS solution. Do not do this. Inspect every sentence to make sure we would be okay with that sentence standing on its own as the headline of an article in the press. Here's an example of paragraph two from the Amazon Location Service PR.

> Location is a vital ingredient in today's applications, enabling capabilities ranging from asset tracking to personalized marketing. However, developers face significant barriers when integrating location data into their applications, including privacy and security compromises, cost, and integration effort. Today, the largest LBS provider imposes licensing terms that grant them rights to access, use, and commercialize the application developer's proprietary business data (e.g., the positions of facilities, assets, or personnel) when that data is overlaid on a licensed map. This creates a privacy concern for application users and a security risk for enterprise application developers. Furthermore, beyond a basic free map service with burdensome licensing, data from the largest LBS provider can be expensive, forcing organizations to use location data sparingly and ruling out many useful location-enabled applications. Finally, integrating LBS data into an application can be tedious and slow. For example, to integrate map data from an LBS provider into an application, a developer must learn the provider's interface and data format, establish an account and security credentials, and onboard the provider as a vendor for their company. After coding their application, the developer must also build health monitoring for their location services, including logs and metrics, before releasing it to production. All of this work can add months to project timelines.

Paragraph Three: Explain the approach or solution: The Knockdown

This paragraph explains how to make the most of the opportunity to help the customer or solve their problem. *See Internal PR Brief part 3c and 3d in Appendix 6.* This paragraph is important because it presents the details that define how the service addresses the issues that were setup in paragraph two. It provides a "knockdown" for each challenge. It should be clear what the usage scenarios are for the service. Here's an example of paragraph three from the Waypoint PR:

> Now, with Waypoint, developers can easily add location data, such as maps, routes, and points of interest, to their applications. With Waypoint, customers retain control of their location data. They can combine proprietary data, such as asset locations, personnel movements, and areas of interest, with Waypoint data without their private information ever leaving their AWS account or being commercialized by an LBS provider. Waypoint provides high-quality LBS data at a price that is up to 20 times lower than the most common LBS provider. Waypoint's data comes from LBS leaders Esri, TomTom, and Mapbox, who are trusted today to route millions of vehicles and power hundreds of thousands of mobile applications and websites. Integrating location information into an application is as easy as calling the Waypoint API. Waypoint provides built-in metrics (e.g., requests, latency, faults) and logs so customers don't have to build their own health monitoring tools. This enables customers to move their applications

> to production more quickly, with the capability to monitor application behavior and pinpoint functional and performance problems.

Paragraph Four: Quote an Amazon Leader to capture the value provided to the customer

This paragraph should capture the value to be provided to the customer (the “why”) concisely and succinctly. It elucidates what is in paragraphs one through three without repeating them. This is, ideally, what we would like a reporter to write. Make sure the Amazon Leader reviews/approves the quote. The quote should respond to the story set up in the challenge and description of the service, and it should speak directly to the service’s main benefit, value proposition, and differentiator–without being too long. The tone should be humble, focusing on the customer benefits, not AWS's achievements. The voice should be professional and conversational as it tells a compelling story. Here’s an example of a quote from an Amazon Leader from the Amazon Location Service PR:

> “Every point on Earth is rich with information that can help developers build more compelling applications,” said Bill Vass, VP of Technology, at AWS. “Developers want to include location data in their applications without giving up control of their proprietary data, paying an excessive price, or incurring the challenges of building and operationalizing third-party integrations. With Amazon Location Service, customers can control their data and innovate quickly, at a fraction of the price of some alternative offerings.”

Paragraph Five: Describe the customer experience

Describe how customers will discover and use what you propose and the value they gain. *See Internal PR Brief party 3f in Appendix 6.* This is important because we want customers who read this paragraph to want to try out the service. Here’s an example of paragraph five from the Amazon Location Service PR:

> Developers can get started easily by using the Amazon Location Service Console or API to simply retrieve location data, such as maps and points of interest. To begin with a more comprehensive working scenario, developers can select a Amazon Location Service example template, such “Calculate Route.” The templates deploy AWS Lambda functions (serverless compute) into the customer’s account, with code showing, for example, the retrieval of a driving route between two points from Amazon Location Service. When moving to production, developers can extend the template for use with their application.

Paragraph Six+: Include customer testimonials

Customer testimonials reinforce why a customer cares about the service. Lead with the strongest, most relevant testimonial (use a separate paragraph for each). Although you will make this up for the initial drafts, the customer testimonial should be specific, believable, and sound like a human being said it. The customer testimonials should speak to the problems identified in paragraph two (the *Setup*) and solved in paragraph three (the *Knockdown*). Include at least 2-3 testimonials. Here are two examples of customer testimonial from the Amazon Location Service PR:

> “We wanted to send targeted advertisements to customers when they were close to our stores, but were deterred by the complexity of integrating with an LBS provider,” said Tessa Quayle, CTO at Starbucks. “After trying the Amazon Location Service example template for geomarketing, we built it into our application. We didn’t have to develop logs and metrics as we hardened the system for production since Amazon Location Service provided these out of the box. Now, our application receives a Amazon

Location Service notification when a customer crosses a 200-yard geofence around our stores and automatically sends the customer a mobile push notification with a special offer. We deployed our location-based offers two months ahead of schedule, because we didn't have to onboard a new vendor and build an integration to their APIs."

Tom Leitch, Software Director at food delivery company Deliveroo, said, "Our customers care about prompt delivery above all else. Saving a few minutes through better routing of delivery riders translates directly to customer retention and revenue; this ultimately depends on having solid data. We have seen great results in our trials with Amazon Location Service in Europe and have been able to cut delivery times by 12% on average. We are thrilled with how we can control our own internal location data with Amazon Location Service, compared with the alternative. For security and privacy reasons, we simply can't integrate with an LBS provider that would use our data to build tracking profiles of our employees and customers."

Final Paragraph: Include a call to action

Tell readers where they go to get started (*e.g.,* a link). To get started with Amazon Location Service, visit https://aws.amazon.com/ AmazonLocationService .

PR Reviewer Checklist

- **Written for a non-technical C-level executive at an AWS customer or a technology trade journalist.**
- **Written in plain English** without technical jargon or buzzwords (like "hyperconverged," "enterprise-grade").
- **Written in a friendly, professional voice**. Active voice. No first person. No vendor or competitor names.
- **Removed wordiness.** Most common feedback from Andy: make the PR "tighter" and "crisper."
- **Put the most important information first.** Assume no one will read past the first paragraph.
- **Stayed positive about AWS** and past efforts. (Each sentence could stand as a positive AWS headline.)
- **Kept paragraphs short and focused**. Include only metrics and data that matter to customers.
- **Made all elements brief, clear, and compelling.** This applies to all descriptions, explanations, and quotes.
- **Read it aloud** to ensure it flows, makes sense, sounds natural, and tells an easy-to-follow, compelling story.

PR Outline – Required Elements	
Heading	**Headline** (typically written as "AWS Announces <x>") ● Correct product and company/organization name ● Short, accurate, and compelling

	Subhead -- one-sentence summary (No end punctuation!) ● Brief, simple, clear, and concrete ● What it is (e.g., instance, tool, portal, service, or feature of an existing service) ● Most important customer benefit(s) ● TIP: Write this last
	List of customers using the new service (if applicable)
Paragraph 1: Description of service/product and what it provides to customers	● City and intended launch date at the beginning ● Most important info in 1st sentence (customer, product description, top benefit) ● Clearly identified customer ● Short, compelling, factual service description (without product name) ● Most important benefits (e.g., lower cost, faster speed, or higher accuracy) ● Relevant category for the service (e.g., machine learning, compute, or analytics) ● Short call-to-action (e.g., “to get started with [service], visit [web page]”)
Paragraph 2: **Opportunity or problem (*the setup*)**	● Explores how existing *external* solutions fall short and/or how existing *internal* solutions work great for certain customers but not others and why ● No negative descriptions of existing AWS solutions ● Explains why industry/customers would care about this ● Describes customer pain points (not just “it’s hard” but why it’s hard)
Paragraph 3: Approach or solution (*the knockdown*)	● Explains how the service addresses each issue from paragraph two ● Clear what the compelling and lasting differentiation is ● Clear what the usage scenarios are for the service

Paragraph 4: **AWS leader quote**	● Captures the value provided to the customer (the “why”) ● Speaks directly to the main benefit, value proposition, and differentiator ● Responds to the story set up in the challenge and description of the service ● Professional yet conversational
Paragraph 5: **Customer experience**	● Explains how a customer would discover, use, and benefit from the service ● Explains how the service connects to/integrates with other AWS services ● Overall impression: should motivate the customer to try the service
Paragraph 6: **Customer quote/testimonials**	● Broad audience appeal – why a customer cares ● 2-3 minimum; strongest quote first; separate paragraphs for each quote ● Covers all the key problems and benefits ● Describe what challenges existing before the product and how they are solved now ● Believable and written in a human voice
Paragraph 7: **Call to action**	Clearly lets customers know what they can do to find out more or try the service (e.g., directs customers to a link)
Footer	● Includes “Amazon Confidential” and page numbers